

Axis Max Life

Displacing the incumbent — a build-versus-configure bid inside a distribution super app

Replacing an entrenched SaaS activity and lead platform for 125,000 sellers across ten distribution channels — where the functional fit was never the hard part.

125K

sellers in scope

10+

distribution channels

58–84K

leads per month

17

months, ten milestones

158

person-months estimated

1

incumbent to displace

PROGRAMME PARAMETERS · AS ISSUED BY THE CLIENT

Activity, lead and renewal management · embedded in the group super app · fixed-bid implementation · named and retained delivery team

Aditya Singh · Solution and deal analysis authored for leadership deal review · 2026

The functional fit was never the question — a displacement bid is won or lost on the commercial model, and this one had five open clauses before it had a scope debate

Situation

A major life insurer runs activity and lead management for roughly 125,000 on-roll and off-role sellers on an entrenched third-party SaaS platform, deep-linked into its own super app.

It wants that capability rebuilt in-house, inside the app, across ten-plus distribution channels.

Complication

Assessed as a solution, this is a good fit: activity catalogues, lead lifecycles and allocation engines are core product territory.

Assessed as a deal it is far harder. The client asks for a bespoke in-house build with full intellectual-property transfer; a product vendor answers with configuration and retains its IP. Those are not two positions on a spectrum — they are different contracts.

The position taken

Bid it as a productised, configuration-led delivery that gives the client the in-house feel, the modularity and the delivery speed it is actually asking for — while resolving IP through escrow or perpetual licence rather than transfer.

And resolve the commercial model before the solution, because no amount of functional fit rescues a contract nobody can sign.

THE NUMBERS THAT MATTER

5

clause families open

3

capability gaps to close

10

milestones, 17 months

158

person-months

~0

change requests targeted

1

decision that gates the rest

The judgement this deck argues: in a displacement bid the incumbent is not the competitor — inertia is. The client is not choosing between two products; it is choosing whether to absorb the cost of change at all, which makes the commercial terms the real battleground.

Scope and volumetrics are the client's; the fit assessment, the deal reading and the recommended position are mine — no live commercial position is disclosed

SCOPE OF WORK

Client context

Requirements, volumes and delivery expectations as issued by the client in the tender pack.

- Functional scope across three domains
- Seller and channel volumetrics
- Integration inventory
- Non-functional and security targets
- Milestone and phasing expectations
- Vendor eligibility conditions

SOLUTION & DEAL ANALYSIS

My contribution

The capability fit matrix, the build-versus-configure reading, the effort shape and the recommended commercial position.

- Four-level fit assessment
- Build / buy / configure framing
- Clause-family analysis
- Effort and role-mix estimate
- Displacement playbook
- Recommendation to leadership

PRE-AWARD ESTIMATE

Estimated

Effort and role mix are a pre-award estimate from the issued scope, not an actual delivery record.

- 158 person-months across 7 roles
- Milestone phasing across 17 months
- Team shape and pod structure
- Sensitive to final scope freeze
- Not a delivered outcome
- Not a priced commercial offer

OUT OF SCOPE

Not claimed

Deliberately excluded. This is a solution and deal analysis, not a bid document and not a delivery record.

- Any live negotiating position
- Any price or rate
- Whether the deal was won
- Delivery of this programme
- The incumbent's identity
- Any confidential client document

Five structural failures drive the displacement — and none of them is a complaint about the incumbent's features

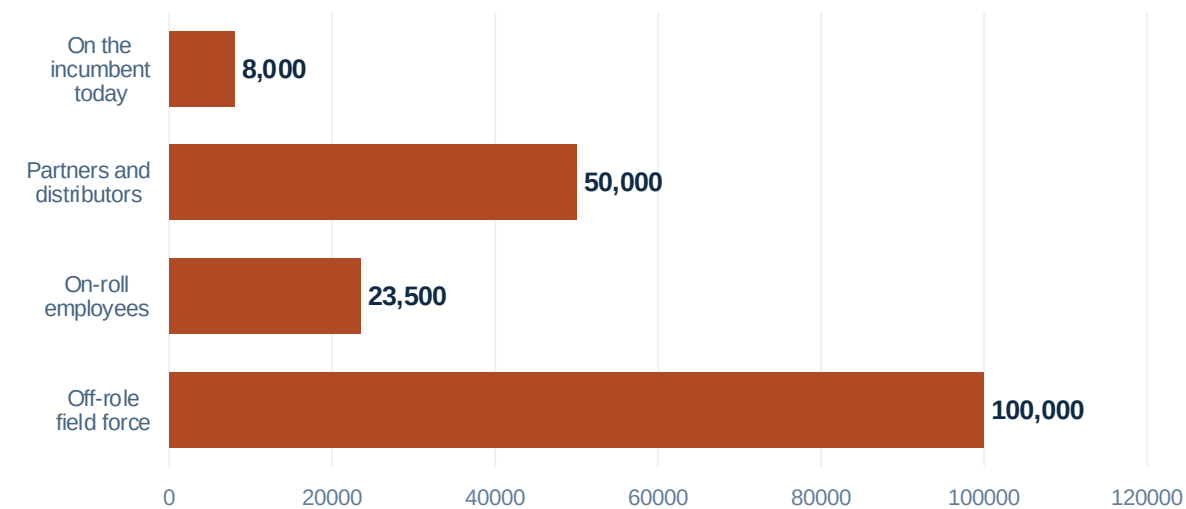
01 No single source of truth Lead and activity records are fragmented across the incumbent platform and peripheral apps. There is no unified record of either.	02 No seller or lead 360 No consolidated view of the seller or the lead across the pre-sales to servicing lifecycle — each system holds a fragment.	03 Transaction and experience overlap Transaction systems overlap with experience platforms across several disparate peripheral applications, with no clear ownership boundary.	04 No CRM-integrated lead view Transactions are not recorded in the CRM, so no end-to-end view of a lead exists anywhere in the estate.	05 No intelligence in the flow The current stack offers sellers no next-best-action, no prioritisation and no AI assistance at the point of work.
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What the list has in common	Why that matters to the bid	What it also implies about risk
• Every failure is an integration or data-model failure, not a functional gap. • The incumbent does activity and lead management perfectly well — inside its own boundary. • The problem is that the boundary exists at all: it sits between the seller's tools and the insurer's record of the customer.	• A response that competes on activity and lead features is answering a question nobody asked. • The winning argument is about where the record lives and what else it connects to. • That reframes a functional bake-off into an architecture conversation — which is where a platform beats a point solution.	• If the failures are integration failures, the replacement inherits every one of those integrations on day one. • The incumbent's scope was narrow, which is partly why it worked. The replacement's scope is not. • That asymmetry is the single biggest delivery risk in the programme and belongs in the estimate, not the appendix.

THE FOOTPRINT

One hundred and twenty-five thousand sellers across ten-plus channels — the scale is what makes configurability an architectural requirement rather than a preference

22–25K	~100K	~6K	~50K	10+	58–84K	8,000	12
on-roll employees	off-role field force	mapped branches	partners and distributors	distribution channels	leads per month	users on the incumbent today	reports in active use



Population by seller type — the incumbent footprint is a fraction of the target estate

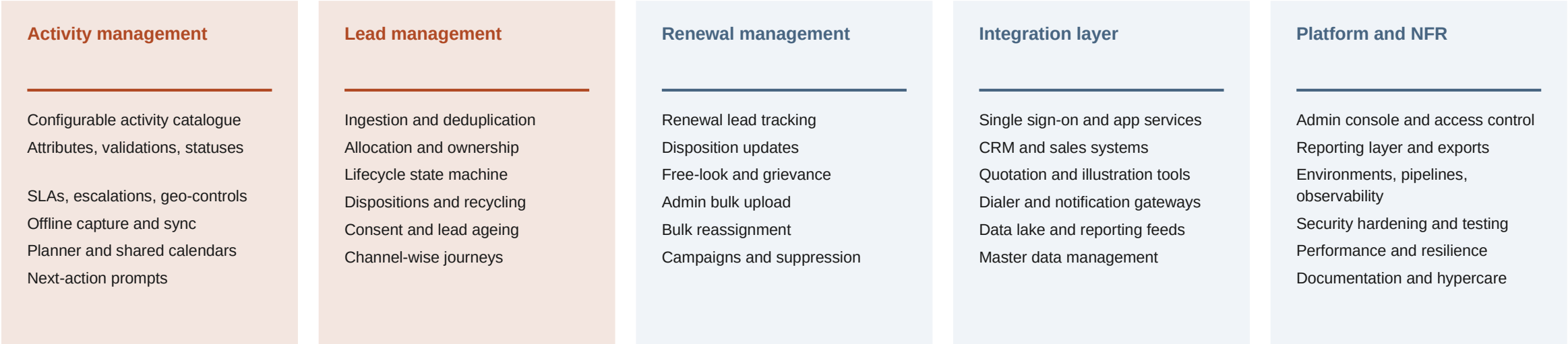
What the gap between 8,000 and 125,000 means

- The replacement is not a like-for-like migration. It is a fifteenfold expansion of the served population, on the same programme.
- The off-role field force is the largest group and the least controllable — low-end devices, poor connectivity, high churn.
- Ten-plus channels each have their own hierarchy, allocation logic and disposition vocabulary.
- At this spread, a change that requires an engineering release is a change that will not happen. Configurability stops being a nice-to-have.

The number that should shape the solution is not 125,000. It is the ratio: the incumbent serves 8,000 users in one channel; the replacement serves fifteen times that across ten. Sizing the replacement against the incumbent's footprint is the estimating error this programme most invites.

SCOPE

Three functional domains, two enabling layers — and the enabling layers are where the effort actually concentrates



What the client is buying	What the supplier is delivering	Where bids go wrong
• The three functional domains — this is what the requirement document is about and where the demonstrations will focus. • It is also the part a product covers natively, which is why the fit assessment looks comfortable.	• The two enabling layers, which carry most of the risk and a disproportionate share of the effort. • Embedding inside the group super app, offline capture across a large low-connectivity field force, and a wide integration inventory.	• Estimating from the functional domains, because that is what the document emphasises and what the demonstration shows. • Then discovering that the container integration, the offline model and the reporting feeds are the actual programme.

Six requirements are native or configurable, three need genuine build, and one is not a technical question at all

Requirement	Assessment	Fit	Risk
Activity management	Configuration-driven activity engine — catalogue, templates, SLAs, assignment rules	NATIVE	Low
Lead management	Ingestion, deduplication, allocation rule engine, lifecycle and recycling — product core	NATIVE	Low
No-code configurability	Field, workflow and rule configuration via admin; changes in days rather than releases	NATIVE	Low
Renewal, free-look, grievance	Lead model extends to renewals; disposition, bulk upload and suppression	CONFIGURABLE	Low
Integration inventory	Interface-first connectors, gateway and queues across the app estate	CONFIGURABLE	Medium
Reporting and role dashboards	Report templates, exports, role KPIs, data-lake and scheduled feeds	CONFIGURABLE	Medium
Embed inside the super app	Runs within the client's own container — requires software-development-kit integration work	BUILD	High
Offline-first mobile capture	Offline sync for low-connectivity field flows — engineering effort per channel	BUILD	High
AI, GenAI and agentic assist	Predictive scoring, next-best-action, coaching and agentic workflows — build plus operations	BUILD	High
Full IP and source handover	Client requires ownership; a product supplier retains it — a contract question, not a technical one	GAP	Blocking

Six of ten are met by configuration and three need real engineering, priced as such. The tenth row is different in kind — a contractual incompatibility no amount of effort closes. Leaving it in a fit matrix as though it were a technical item is how it survives to contract stage unresolved.

Two framings of the same programme — and a third position that gives each side what it actually needs

THE CLIENT'S FRAMING

Build it in-house

- A bespoke capability, replacing the SaaS incumbent
- Full intellectual property and source ownership
- Delivered in an AI-assisted, pod-based pattern
- Fixed bid, named resources, no change-request fees

VERSUS

THE SUPPLIER'S FRAMING

Configure the product

- Configure an existing platform, not a ground-up build
- Licence priced separately from implementation
- Intellectual property remains with the supplier
- Third-party software and hosting procured by the client

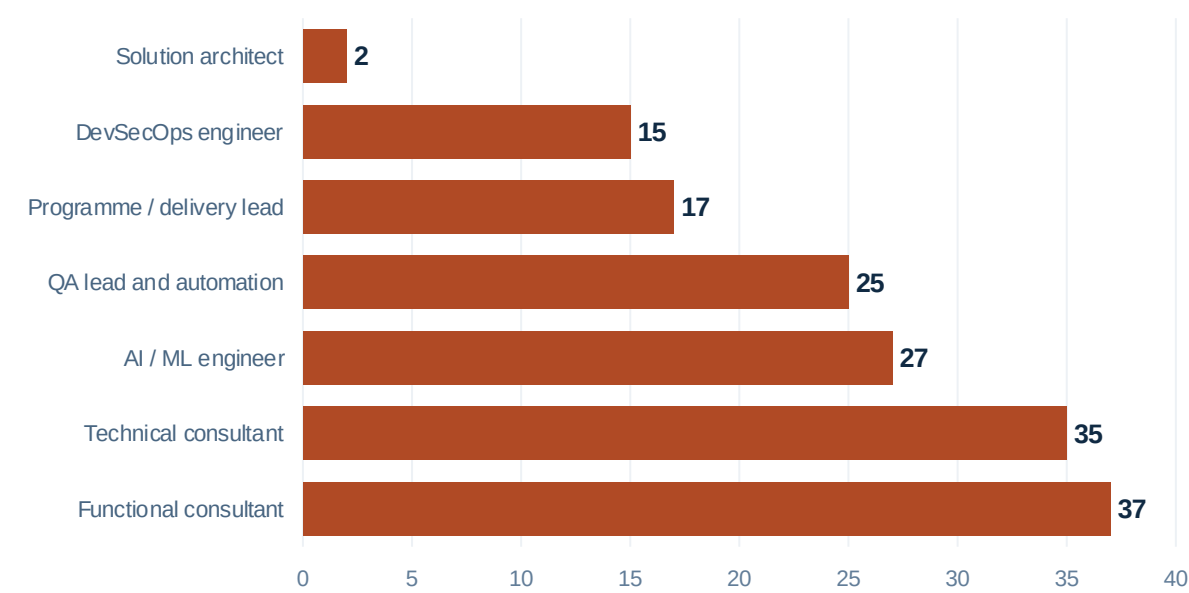
The third position — what each side actually needs

The client's underlying needs are control, speed of change and freedom from a vendor that can raise prices or withdraw a feature. None of those requires source-code ownership; all of them are satisfied by configurability the client operates itself, a perpetual licence, and source held in escrow against defined trigger events.

The supplier's underlying need is to avoid handing over a product it also sells to the client's competitors. That is satisfied by transferring everything built specifically for the client, while retaining the platform beneath it — a boundary that must be drawn explicitly in the contract, not left to interpretation.

The recommended stance: position the programme as a productised, configuration-led delivery that gives the client the in-house feel, modularity and delivery speed it is asking for, while resolving ownership through escrow and perpetual licence. The gap is not technical fit. It is the commercial model, and it has to be resolved before the solution is finalised — not after.

One hundred and fifty-eight person-months across seven roles — and the mix says more about the programme than the total does



Estimated effort by role — pre-award estimate from the issued scope

158

person-months estimated

15

resources across seven roles

17

months, ten milestones

17%

of effort in AI and ML

What the mix reveals

- Functional effort exceeds technical — consistent with configuration-led delivery, not a ground-up build.
- A sixth of effort sits in AI and machine learning, the least certain line in the estimate.
- Two person-months of architecture is thin for work embedded in someone else's container.

Where I would challenge this estimate before submission

Two lines look optimistic against the scope. Architecture at two person-months does not cover integration into a client-owned container plus offline synchronisation across ten channels — that is design work with a long approval path. And AI at twenty-seven assumes model operations are inherited rather than built; if scoring, next-best-action and agentic assist are genuinely new, that is a floor. Both belong in the risk register with a named contingency, not absorbed into the fixed bid.

Six things that make a displacement bid different from a greenfield one — and that most proposal templates get wrong

01 Compete against inertia, not the incumbent

The alternative to your bid is not the other vendor. It is doing nothing for another eighteen months. Every objection you answer should be an objection to changing at all.

02 Inherit the incumbent's scope, then some

The incumbent works partly because its boundary is narrow. Yours will not be. Size against the target estate, never against the deployment being replaced.

03 Name the switching cost yourself

Migration, retraining, dual running and lost productivity are real and the client already knows it. Pricing them openly is more credible than a proposal that pretends they are zero.

04 Make the first release smaller than asked

A displacement is judged on whether the first cutover was painful. A narrow, boring, early go-live buys more credibility than a broad one that slips.

05 Resolve the contract before the solution

Functional fit gets you shortlisted. Clause families decide whether anyone can sign. Sequencing those the other way round is how good bids die at legal review.

06 Design the incumbent's exit, not just your entry

Data extraction, historical records and the disposition vocabulary all sit inside the platform being removed. Whoever plans that first controls the timeline.

Four judgements that carry to any displacement pursuit

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|----|---|---|
| 01 | Separate the fit question from the deal question | Functional fit and contractual fit are assessed differently and fail differently. A capability matrix that lists a contract incompatibility as though it were a feature gap will carry that problem all the way to signature. |
| 02 | Read stated positions for underlying needs | Full source ownership is a stated position. Control, speed of change and freedom from vendor risk are the underlying needs — and escrow plus a perpetual licence satisfies all three without transferring the product. |
| 03 | Size against the target, not the incumbent | The platform being replaced usually serves a fraction of the target population in a fraction of the channels. Benchmarking effort against it is the most reliable way to under-price a displacement. |
| 04 | Challenge your own estimate before the client does | Two thin lines in an otherwise sound estimate — architecture and new AI capability — are worth naming in the risk register with a contingency, rather than absorbed silently into a fixed bid. |

In a displacement, functional fit gets you shortlisted and the commercial model decides the outcome. Sequencing those the other way round is the most common and most expensive mistake in this kind of pursuit.